



Smart quad

A new quadcopter called LilyCamera can fly itself when thrown in the air. Read more at: <http://dgit.in/1LdqIvi>



Going Bananas

A banana's DNA is 50% identical to that of a human. <http://dgit.in/1QX0wIA>

How to do Memes Right

Meme (n): an element of a culture or system of behaviour passed from one individual to another by imitation or other non-genetic means.

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That, up there, is the textbook definition of a meme. Sadly, you've already lost the game if you have to look the word up in a dictionary. This sentiment is captured well in a pivotal scene from Mike Judge's cult classic *Office Space*, wherein a bunch of white-collar software programmers realise the futility of looking up the term "money laundering" in a dictionary. The true understanding of memes, pretty much in the same way, is best imbued in an organic manner with experience rather than through rote academic research.

To explain it in a more Internet-centric fashion, a meme constitutes anything from an image, video, or even simply some text representing mostly humorous themes. However, it's differentiated from a regular joke in that a meme is usually a template that is slightly modified and then propagated between Internet users. Another significant factor distinguishing it from a regular joke is the logic – or the apparent lack of the same underpinning it. Unlike your regular form of humour, memes are mostly comprised of uncanny non sequiturs that are deeply contextual. In other words, the ability to 'get' a meme requires a person to be aware of the original context, or at least have a deep understanding of the same.

If that seemed hard to understand, don't despair because it's not meant to be a cut-and-dried affair.

The very concept of memes is just as hard to explain as it is to understand the humour underlying the often indecipherable examples. Best explained as inside jokes of the Internet age, memes however differ in one crucial aspect that defines



inside jokes – the sheer number of people sharing them. The unprecedented reach of the medium ensures that these seemingly obscure references are sometimes shared by the teeming millions that populate the underbelly of the Internet.

Breaking into the Mainstream

The very fact that you – as the quintessential layman – are interested in this phenomenon speaks volumes of the meteoric rise of this cultural currency. Although memes originated in the dark underbelly of the Internet, it has trickled down to the masses thanks to the proliferation of social networking websites such as Facebook and Twitter. However, nothing establishes its ubiquity as well as the inevitable adoption by the film and advertising industries, as well as by the marketing machinery.

Not surprisingly, the *Grumpy Cat* meme made its way to Hollywood as a titular character of a film starring Aubrey Plaza and funny man Russell Peters. *Scumbag Steve*, the curiously named meme based on the quintessential selfish friend that everyone knows, caught the attention of Pepsi Co, which used the meme to market one of its beverages. Samsung leveraged the inherent creepiness of the *Overly Attached Girlfriend* meme to sell SSD drives. The list goes on, but the crux of the matter is that Internet memes are breaking out of their original domain and into mainstream media.

The true spirit of memes, however, transcends the sanitised PG13 world of mainstream entertainment and commercial marketing. Memes resonate with the masses mainly because they are entirely user-generated. A successful meme is too